UDL FOR LITTLE LEARNERS · BONUS TOOLKIT

Planning for Play: A UDL Toolkit

Firm goals, flexible play. Tools to plan, protect, and notice the learning that happens when young children play.

8 PAGES

A NOTE FROM JEFF

Maria Montessori is often credited with saying that **play is the work of the child.** Anyone who has watched a four-year-old build a block tower knows it's true.

So why isn't there a chapter on play in *UDL for Little Learners*? Partly because play runs through every chapter: centers, recess, dramatic play, the carpet with the blocks. But also because of what I see in so many classrooms from kindergarten on up: **play starts to disappear.** The schedule fills, the pressure to prove learning grows, and play is the first thing cut.

That's a loss, because play is already one of the most universally designed parts of a child's day. It's student-centered and child-driven. It's flexible. It's full of agency and choice. Kids find their own way in and show what they know with their hands, their bodies, their voices, and their stories. When we add UDL thinking, we're not taking play away from children. We're naming the goal, predicting what might get in the way, and making sure *every* child can get into the game, in preschool and well beyond it.

That's what this toolkit is for. Use one page or use them all. Bring it to your team. And then go play.

— Jeff

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WAYS TO USE IT

- **On your own:** Plan one play center with page 5, then observe it with page 7.
- **With your team:** Do page 3 together for a goal you all share.
- **Coaches and leaders:** Use page 7 on learning walks during center or choice time.
- **With families:** Send home page 8 at conferences or open house.

The big idea: firm goals, flexible play

In the book, I talk about firm goals and flexible means: the goal stays fixed, and the pathways flex. Play is the most flexible pathway we have. The move this toolkit asks you to make is small. Before play time starts, **name the goal you're hoping play will grow**. Then design the space, the materials, and your own role so every child has a way in. You don't have to script the play. You just have to plan for it.

01 Name the goal

What could children learn or practice here? Social, language, math, motor, regulation. Pick one or two, not ten.

02 Predict the barriers

Who might not be able to get in, stay in, or show what they know? Design for them first.

03 Notice the learning

Watch, listen, and jot. Play is where kids show us things they can't yet show on a worksheet.

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THE FRAMEWORK

Play Is Already UDL

Play is student-centered and child-driven, with agency and choice built in. It naturally offers multiple means of engagement, representation, and action and expression. Our job is to protect that, and design it on purpose.

PAGE 2

ENGAGEMENT

The why of learning

IN PLAY, CHILDREN…

- Choose what to do and who to do it with
- Persist through frustration because they care
- Practice regulation: waiting, sharing, recovering when the tower falls

DESIGN MOVES

- Offer real choice of play area, materials, and partners
- Rotate materials tied to children's interests
- Protect long, uninterrupted blocks of play time
- Build in a calm spot and a "take a break" option

REPRESENTATION

The what of learning

IN PLAY, CHILDREN…

- Meet ideas through touch, movement, sound, and story
- Use objects to stand for other things (a block becomes a phone)
- Hear and use new vocabulary in context

DESIGN MOVES

- Add picture labels, word banks, and books to every area
- Include materials that reflect children's families, languages, and cultures
- Model play scripts and new words, then step back
- Mix open-ended and real-world materials

ACTION & EXPRESSION

The how of learning

IN PLAY, CHILDREN…

- Show what they know by building, acting, drawing, and telling
- Plan, try, revise, and try again
- Communicate with words, gestures, signs, devices, and drawings

DESIGN MOVES

- Accept many ways to show the same goal
- Provide adaptive tools: chunky grips, easy-open bins, communication boards or buttons
- Offer simple plan-do-review routines
- Photograph and document play as evidence of learning

Play isn't one thing: the playful learning spectrum

Researchers describe play as a spectrum based on who starts it and whether there's a learning goal. All of these belong in early childhood. UDL helps us choose on purpose.

Free play	Guided play	Playful games	Playful instruction
Child-led, no adult goal. Children choose, invent, and direct. Builds agency, creativity, and social problem-solving.	**Child-led, adult-designed.** The adult sets up the space or materials with a goal in mind, then follows the child's lead.	**Rules with a goal.** Board games, movement games, and circle games that build a specific skill.	**Adult-led with play elements.** A lesson with choice, movement, novelty, and fun built in.

◀ MORE CHILD-DIRECTED

MORE ADULT-DIRECTED ▶

ASK YOURSELF

- ☐ Where does play live in my day right now? If I teach K or up, has it quietly disappeared?
- ☐ When I say "play time," do I have a goal in mind, or is it a break?
- ☐ Which children rarely get to lead play? Which rarely get to follow?
- ☐ What would I show a skeptical colleague or family as evidence that play is learning?

Grounded in: CAST (2024). *Universal Design for Learning Guidelines version 3.0.* udlguidelines.cast.org · NAEYC (2020). *Developmentally Appropriate Practice* position statement · Weisberg, D. S., Hirsh-Pasek, K., & Golinkoff, R. M. (2013). Guided play: Where curricular goals meet a playful pedagogy. *Mind, Brain, and Education, 7*(2) · Zosh, J. M., et al. (2018). Accessing the inaccessible: Redefining play as a spectrum. *Frontiers in Psychology, 9* · Yogman, M., et al. (2018). The power of play. *Pediatrics, 142*(3).

WORKED EXAMPLE

One Goal, Many Ways to Play

Start with the goal, then spread it across your play spaces. Same target, different entry points. Children choose where they play, and the learning meets them there.

FIRM GOAL

Recognize and name uppercase and lowercase letters.

The kindergarten standard from Chapter 1 (CCSS.ELA-Literacy.RF.K.1.d). Swap in any goal from your own standards or curriculum.

PLAY SPACE	WHAT CHILDREN MIGHT DO	WHAT WE ADD (MATERIALS)	WHAT WE MIGHT HEAR
Blocks	Build letters with unit blocks; make signs for their structures; "deliver" letter blocks by truck	Letter cards on clipboards, tape and markers for signs, alphabet blocks	**"I made a K. It has a stick and two arms."**
Dramatic play	Run a post office: sort mail by first letter, write names on envelopes, read addresses	Envelopes, name cards with photos, mail slots labeled A–Z, stamps	**"This one's for Maya. M, M, Maya!"**
Sensory table	Dig for buried magnetic letters, match them to a letter mat, trace letters in sand	Magnetic letters, sand or rice, scoops, laminated letter mats	**"I found a little b! Where's the big one?"**
Art & maker	Form letters from playdough, pipe cleaners, or loose parts; make a name collage	Playdough mats, wikki stix, loose parts, letter photo cards	**"My S is a snake. Sssss."**
Movement & outside	Letter hopscotch; body letters; chalk letter hunt; "find something that starts with..."	Sidewalk chalk, letter beanbags, clipboard scavenger hunt	**"Jump on the T! Now the t!"**
Games	Letter Bingo, Go Fish with letters, letter memory match, I Spy	Letter cards with pictures, bingo boards with visual supports	**"Do you have an R? Go fish!"**

Your turn

Choose one goal. Fill in at least three play spaces. Then ask: does every child in my class have a way in?

Firm goal: _____

PLAY SPACE	WHAT CHILDREN MIGHT DO	WHAT WE ADD	WHAT WE MIGHT HEAR

BEFORE: PLAN IT

Predicting Barriers to Play

Not every child walks into play time ready to play. Check the barriers you see in your room, then try a design move. Plan for the margins and everyone benefits.

BARRIER: CHECK WHAT YOU SEE	DESIGN MOVE: TRY THIS
GETTING IN AND STAYING IN	
☐ Children don't know how to join play, or get turned away	Teach and role-play joining language at morning meeting: **"Can I play?" "What are you playing?" "I can be the..."** Post the stems with pictures where play happens.
☐ Children wander, flit, or can't settle on anything	Use a simple plan board: children choose and place their photo before play. Offer a "first, then" or a short checklist for that area.
☐ The same children always lead; others always watch	Add roles to dramatic play and games (cashier, customer, builder, inspector) and rotate them. Notice and name what quieter players contribute.
ACCESS: BODY, SENSES, AND COMMUNICATION	
☐ Materials or spaces are hard to reach, grip, or move through	Store materials low and labeled. Add chunky grips, larger pieces, and table-height options. Ask your OT what one change would open up the most.
☐ The play space is too loud, crowded, or bright for some	Limit the number of players per area with a visual cue. Offer headphones and a quiet play option, like a basket of fidgets or a one-person build spot.
☐ Children are learning English or have limited speech	Add picture word banks and core-word boards to each area. Use recordable buttons for key play phrases. Value gesture, pointing, and acting it out as full participation.
MATERIALS, TIME, AND ADULTS	
☐ Materials are all closed-ended (one right way) or all open-ended (no way in)	Mix both. Pair open-ended loose parts with a few picture "challenge cards" so children who need a starting point have one, and others can ignore them.
☐ Play time is short, interrupted, or the first thing cut	Protect a long block when you can. Give a two-minute warning with a visual timer and a "save it" sign so work can continue later.
☐ Adults either take over play or step out of it completely	Agree as a team on your stances (see page 6). Assign one adult to observe and document during each play block.
☐ Families or colleagues see play as "not learning"	Name the goal on a small sign in each area. Share photos with captions about the learning. Send home page 8.
BEHAVIOR AND BIG FEELINGS	
☐ Arguments over materials, roles, or the rules of the game	Have more than one of the favorite things. Post the problem-solving language from page 6, and use a sand timer or a waitlist clipboard for turns.
☐ Play gets too physical: crashing, grabbing, rough play	Look for the need underneath. A child crashing cars may be seeking speed and force. Give it a safe place, like a ramp or a taped "zoom track," with clear body rules.
☐ A child gets too excited and can't come back down	Watch for early signs and step in calmly before it peaks. Keep a calm option nearby, use a predictable pause cue, and plan the transition out of play.

Behavior is information. What a child argues over, crashes, or can't stop doing tells you what they value and care about. Use it to plan the rest of your day (see page 7).

BEFORE: PLAN IT · TEMPLATE

Play Center Planner

Plan one play area or one play block. Keep the goal firm, keep the play flexible.

Teacher: _____ **Date:** _____ **Play area:** _____

Firm goal

What could children learn or practice here? One or two goals, not ten.

01 Set it up

What materials invite the goal?

OPEN-ENDED MATERIALS

STARTING POINTS (CHALLENGE CARDS, MODELS, BOOKS)

WAYS IN: CHECK ALL THAT APPLY

- [ ] Picture labels or word bank
- [ ] Materials that reflect my students
- [ ] Adaptive tools or larger pieces
- [ ] Roles to choose from
- [ ] A quiet or solo option
- [ ] Communication board or buttons

OTHER WAYS IN

02 Predict barriers

Who might not get in, stay in, or show what they know? (See page 4.)

BARRIERS I PREDICT

MY DESIGN MOVE

CHILDREN I'LL CHECK IN WITH

03 Play & notice

What's my role, and what will I look and listen for?

MY STANCE (PAGE 6)

- [ ] Observer
- [ ] Stage manager
- [ ] Co-player
- [ ] Narrator
- [ ] Coach

WORDS I'LL MODEL

EVIDENCE OF THE GOAL LOOKS / SOUNDS LIKE

After play: what did I notice?

What will I change, add, or remove next time?

DURING: PLAY IT

The Adult's Role in Play

The question isn't whether to be involved in play. It's how. Move between these stances based on what children need in the moment, and step back as soon as they've got it.

STANCE	WHEN TO USE IT	WHAT IT MIGHT SOUND LIKE
Observer	Play is going well. You want to learn what children know and can do.	Nothing yet. Watch, listen, take a photo, jot a note. **Silence is a strategy.**
Stage manager	Play is stalled or needs a nudge, but you don't want to take over.	Add a prop, move a material, offer a space. **"I wonder if the builders need a sign for their bridge?"**
Co-player	Children need a model of how to play, or a way into the group.	Take a role and follow their lead. **"Can I be a customer? I'd like a pizza with... what toppings do you have?"**
Narrator	You want to build language and help children notice their own thinking.	Describe without judging. **"You put the biggest block on the bottom. Now you're adding the smaller ones."**
Coach	There's a conflict, a safety issue, or a child who can't get in on their own.	Give words, then step back. **"Try saying, 'Can I have a turn when you're done?' I'll stay close."**

Questions that stretch play

Open questions invite thinking. Use one, then wait.

- **"Tell me about what you made."**
- **"What do you think will happen if...?"**
- **"How could you make it taller / longer / stronger?"**
- **"How many do you think are there? How could we find out?"**
- **"What does your customer need next?"**
- **"What's another way you could...?"**
- **"How did you figure that out?"**

Language for children to practice

Role-play these at morning meeting before play. Post them with pictures.

JOINING

"Can I play?" · "What are you playing?" · "I can be the..."

SHARING AND TURNS

"Can I have a turn when you're done?" · "Let's use it together."

SOLVING PROBLEMS

"I don't like that. Please stop." · "Let's take turns." · "I need a teacher."

INVITING OTHERS

"Do you want to play?" · "You can be the..."

FROM THE CLASSROOM: CO-PLAYER IN ACTION

I was in a preschool classroom recently during free choice time. One student was sitting at a table zooming a car around. I sat down with him and asked if that was a fast car, and immediately we were friends. He showed me how it could drift and do jumps. He even flipped it. In that one conversation, I learned what he likes and started building a relationship.

Shortly after, a child from the kitchen came over, and then my most favorite activity happened. I asked her if she would make me something to eat. "Of course!" she said. She went back to the kitchen and concocted something. From there, I started working on vocabulary: asking her what she made, whether she had cabbage or parsnips to add, and on and on. **We were all having fun, but we were also working, learning, growing, and connecting.**

AFTER: NOTICE IT · FOR TEACHERS, COACHES & LEADERS

Play Look-Fors

Use during center or choice time to notice UDL in play. This is a conversation starter, not an evaluation. Note what you see, then talk about it together.

Classroom: _____ **Date:** _____ **Play time observed:** _____

LOOK-FOR	SEEN	NOT YET	EVIDENCE / NOTES
ENGAGEMENT			
Children choose where, what, and with whom they play	☐	☐	
Materials connect to children's interests, cultures, and lives	☐	☐	
Play time is long enough for children to go deep	☐	☐	
A quiet or calm option is available	☐	☐	
REPRESENTATION			
Play areas have picture labels, word banks, or books	☐	☐	
Adults model vocabulary and play ideas, then step back	☐	☐	
The learning goal is visible or can be named by the adults	☐	☐	
ACTION & EXPRESSION			
Children show learning in more than one way (build, act, draw, tell)	☐	☐	
Materials and spaces are reachable and usable for every child	☐	☐	
Children communicate in many ways (words, signs, gestures, devices)	☐	☐	
Play is documented (photos, notes, work samples) as evidence of learning	☐	☐	

FROM HOME: WHAT PLAY TELLS US

When my son was young, he loved cars. We zoomed cars every day, sometimes before dawn and well into the night. He liked the physicalness of zooming them hard. He liked seeing them drift. He liked the difference between small ones and big ones, fast ones and slow ones.

That's not just play. It's information about what a child values: speed, force, movement, and comparing. In a classroom, those interests can show up all day: counting and sorting cars in math, racing stories in writing, a car-themed greeting at morning meeting. **Play shows us what a child loves. We can use it everywhere else.**

A moment of learning I noticed

What did a child say or do? What goal does it show?

What does this child love?

What they value, and where else it could show up in our day.

FOR FAMILIES

Why We Play at School

When you see your child playing in our classroom, you're seeing them learn. Here's what's happening, and how you can keep it going at home.

There's a saying often credited to Maria Montessori: **play is the work of the child.**

Young children learn best by doing: touching, building, pretending, talking, and trying again. When children play, they make choices, lead, and follow their curiosity. In our classroom, play is planned. We set up spaces and materials with learning goals in mind, and then we let children lead. That way, every child can find a way in and show us what they know in their own way.

What your child is learning through play

🧱 Building with blocks

Counting, measuring, shapes, balance, planning, and solving problems when things fall down.

🏰 Pretend play

New words, storytelling, taking turns, seeing things from someone else's point of view.

🎨 Art and making

Hand strength for writing, creativity, colors and shapes, sharing ideas without words.

🤸 Outdoor and movement play

Balance and coordination, joining a game, following rules, and handling big feelings.

🧩 Puzzles and games

Patience, patterns, matching, early math, and winning (and losing) kindly.

💧 Sand, water, and sensory play

Science thinking ("What happens if...?"), calming the body, and describing what they notice.

Easy ways to play at home

- **Follow their lead.** Let your child choose the game, and join in as a player, not the boss.
- **Talk about what they're doing.** "You stacked three cups! What will you add next?"
- **Use everyday stuff.** Boxes, pots and spoons, laundry baskets, and blankets are some of the best toys there are.
- **Ask "I wonder" questions.** "I wonder what would happen if we added more water?"
- **Leave room for boredom.** Unplanned time is when kids invent their own play.
- **Play in your home language.** Stories, songs, and games in any language build your child's learning.

A NOTE FROM YOUR CHILD'S TEACHER